from the truth in order to survive. The Persians invented the art of negotiation and bargaining, which is inherent in the bazaar culture. The beaming seller will extol the virtues of his wares and praise the buyer's good taste, proclaiming what a perfect choice he has made in the product he is about to buy; at the outset of the negotiations he will declare that for this particular buyer he is willing to sell at a loss, and he will offer the buyer hot tea until he has steam coming out of his ears. He will wear the buyer out and sell him the goods at an exorbitant price, even after all the discounts he offered over the course of the negotiations.

Patience is a profound and fundamental characteristic of the Iranians. The Persian will tell you that patience is the source of all victories in negotiations, whether it is bargaining in the bazaar or political negotiations. Patience, according to the Persians, increases your chances of achieving your goals. And when you ask where this patience is supposed to come from, you will be offered the metaphor that a carpet takes years to weave! And carpet weaving is a uniquely Iranian art.

Of course, these are all generalizations, and they do not apply to all Persians everywhere. However, I would say that anyone who has been to Iran, and perhaps the Iranians themselves, will confirm that the things I have described are characteristic of many, if not most, of the Persian people.

Much similarity can be found between the period of the shah and the era of the sharia (Islamic religious law) state with regard to the characteristics of the regime. During the shah's rule, he was called "the Light of the Aryans," and his subjects regarded him as a divine manifestation on earth. The security services he established, SAVAK, which included the domestic security service and the military intelligence service, as well as police and gendarmerie bodies, terrorized citizens and used any means necessary to suppress any expression of opposition to the shah's regime.

In today's sharia state, the spiritual leader Khamenei and Khomeini before him are considered the spokesmen of Allah, and therefore the citizens accept everything that comes out of their mouths as the word of Allah. This belief gives the spiritual leader veto power and the authority to make the final decision on every matter. In other words, the spiritual leader has ultimate authoritarian power. The equivalent of the shah's security services in the era of the sharia state is the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), which controls all of the security services and their own